"We're terrible colonizers": the numbers

"אנחנו קולוניאליסטים גרועים": המספרים

Real empires spread their language across continents. Here is the leaderboard behind the reel: how far each empire's language reached, and where Hebrew stands.

אימפריות אמיתיות הפיצו את השפה שלהן על פני יבשות. הנה הטבלה שמאחורי הסרטון: עד כמה הגיעה השפה של כל אימפריה, ואיפה העברית.

The leaderboard

הטבלה

Language / empire	Speakers (L1+L2)	Official in	Peak empire area
English / British Empire	1,530M	58 countries	35.5M km² (1920)
Spanish / Spanish Empire	561M	20 countries	13.7M km² (1810)
Standard Arabic / Umayyad Caliphate	335M	24 countries	11.1M km² (720)
French / French colonial empire	334M	26 countries	11.5M km² (1920)
Russian / Russian Empire	210M	4 countries	22.8M km² (1895)
German / German colonial empire	133M	6 countries	3.1M km² (1911)
Japanese / Empire of Japan	126M	1 country	7.4M km² (1942)
Hebrew / Israel	about 10M	1 country	not on any empire list

Speakers: Ethnologue 2026 (one edition for all, since it changes every year). Areas: Rein Taagepera's estimates. Standard Arabic is counted as a second language, because Arabs first learn a local dialect.

Hebrew: born here

עברית: נולדה כאן

- A Canaanite language of the Southern Levant, written here from the 10th century BCE.
- Spoken as a first language until after 200 CE, revived as a spoken language in the late 19th century.
- Today: over 10 million people speak it, about 6.5 million natively (Israel CBS, 2023 survey).

> **The honest caveat:** about 2,100 years ago, the Hasmonean kings forced two conquered peoples, the Idumeans and the Itureans, to convert (per Josephus; scholars debate how forced it was). Since then, Judaism has had no mission to convert others. Today: about 2.3 billion Christians, 2.0 billion Muslims and 14.8 million Jews (Pew, 2025).

In my view: speaker numbers measure spread, not morality. But if we were colonizers, we did a terrible job of it.

Sources

מקורות

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